UPFRONT

ECOWATCH: TIGER ATTACKS, AI ALERTS *PG 14*

COLUMN: A WINDOW AFTER A STALEMATE *PG 16*



JUMPING SHIP AAP Rajya Sabha MPs make their move, with BJP president Nitin Nabin (centre)

ANI

▶ NDA IN PARLIAMENT

THE QUEST FOR TWO-THIRDS

After the setback over the Constitution Amendment Bill, the BJP has taken it upon itself to raise the NDA's numbers in both Houses by any means necessary

By ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

EVEN BEFORE THE DUST HAD BEGUN TO SETTLE on the splintering Trinamool Congress (TMC), news channels were flashing reports of a similar discomfort in Maharashtra, with MPs of the Shiv Sena (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) turning up in Delhi. Four years after the rebellion that split the party and brought down the Maha Vikas Aghadi government, the fight over Bal Thackeray's legacy may be entering a second phase, this time in Parliament. Days after Shiv Sena MLC Krupal Tumane, of the Eknath Shinde faction, claimed that seven of the nine Sena (UBT) Lok Sabha MPs would cross over before the monsoon session, on June 17, there were reports that a 'group' of them had met Lok Sabha speaker, Om Birla. The group reportedly claimed support of six Sena (UBT) MPs—the two-third numbers needed to evade the anti-defection law. Whether the move materialises or not, one thing is clear: the Parliament that meets for the monsoon session will be quiet different from the one that adjourned after the special session in April, especially with regard to the numbers of the ruling BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

To see why that matters, recall where the BJP stood when Parliament last rose. Its managers had reason to feel let down. On April 17, the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, which sought to put the 33 per cent women's reservation into effect immediately by